

Brandon Startz

A versatile mixed-methods researcher with strong multidisciplinary skills and hands-on experience. Grounded in user research, with excellent communication skills and software-development know-how.



Work Experience



AI Developer Training

Playful Pixels Oy, Helsinki, Finland

March 2025 - July 2025 (Fixed-term)

- Assisted with testing and integration of AI features such as image generation
- Gained exposure to cutting-edge models with an architecture that blends several models' responses



Lead Game Developer and User Researcher

Music Fairy Tales Oy, Helsinki, Finland

February 2023 - December 2023

- Led Unity development of a serious game for children; integrated analytics to inform design
- Ran user research with children and domain experts (psychologists); methods included observational studies, interviews, and surveys



Player Analyst

HypeHype Inc., Helsinki, Finland

November 2021 - December 2022

- Built and deployed an NLP tool for automated playtest analysis using sentiment classification
- Conducted mixed-methods user research, guided user-focused design, and presented team-wide research reports



Research Assistant

Helsinki & Aalto University, Finland (2018-2021)

- Evaluated emotional UX (EEG, eye-tracking) in HCI studies (HIIT Lab)
- Prototyped interactive IoT systems for smart campus experiences (UbiKampus)
- Conducted comprehensive investigation on player motivation and SDT (Aalto Games Lab)

Education



Masters of Arts in Video Game Design and Production

Aalto University, 2020-2022

Thesis: NLP-based tool for automating emotional playtest analysis (Eximia cum laude)

Focus: Game-based learning and user research



Bachelor of Science in Psychology

Bachelor of Arts in Spanish Language

Minor: Cognitive Science

Oklahoma State University, 2012-2018

Multi-year lab research on attention, learning, anxiety & depression using behavioral and physiological methods

GPA: 3.72/4

Contact Info

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- US & Finnish dual-citizen

Research methods

- Interviews & Surveys
- Usability studies
- Experimental design
- Mixed-methods analysis

Programming

- Python: Data Analysis & NLP
- C#: Unity game engine
- .NET/Blazor: full-stack dev
- SQL: Query & structure data
- OpenAI API: build & eval AI

Software

- Unity Game Engine
- Tableau
- Canva / Figma
- Jupyter / Colab
- Version Control (Git)

Languages

- English Native
- Spanish B2
- Swedish B2
- Italian B1
- German A2